

fridayReview

THE HINDU

A play on the Trinity
Looking at the life and musical journey of Tyagaraja, Dikshitar and Syama Sastri **p2**

Bond with the bansuri
Meet sisters Suchismita and Debopriya, pioneering flautists in Hindustani music **p4**



FOR THE LOVE OF THE BLUES
Shemekia Copeland to perform at the Mahindra Blues Festival in Mumbai **p5**

The lyrical heartbeat

Looking at how Jayadeva's *Gita Govinda*, a 12th century poem, continues to evoke the many shades of love

I was fortunate to learn exquisite dance choreographies of the Ashtapadi directly from my mentor and guru Kelucharan Mohapatra, whose renditions of the same have become legendary. Through his guidance, the poetry revealed itself to me not only as literature, but as a living tradition – where love flows into movement, devotion into rhythm and art into a universal language.

The poet's vision of Radha and Krishna's love has been interpreted in many ways over the centuries, with scholars and commentators adapting it to align with their individual philosophical perspectives.

Over time, their divine union came to symbolise many profound ideas: the merging of the *atma* with the *paramatma*, the longing of the individual soul to unite with the universal one, the devotee's desire to become one with God, and even the rising of *kundalini* towards spiritual awakening.

But why Jayadeva chose the metaphor of the Radha-Krishna love for his great literary work is impossible to decipher. What we do know is that he was both a deeply romantic person and an ardent devotee of Jagadisha or Jagannath. No wonder, then, that he chose to worship through the finest gift he possessed – his literary talent – and used it to depict the infinite shades of love.

Jayadeva's wife Padmavati symbolised an ideal companion – one who both inspires him

with her beauty and grace, yet never distracts him from his purpose. Without her, the many-layered love that Jayadeva lends to the character of Radha might not have been possible.

The sensuous, musical cadence of Sanskrit in this poem, intertwined with its erotic undertones and the poet's fervent spiritual quest, elevates the *kavya* to a superior level seldom attained by any literary work before or since. Radha and Krishna, though revered in popular belief as divine beings, are portrayed here as human lovers tormented by the anguish of separation.

Krishna, throughout the poem, is invoked through the many epithets familiar in Vaishnava literature, yet he is consistently humanised.

Krishna is introduced as a small child in the very beginning of the poem, who is afraid to go home alone through the forest because

of the impending darkness. Then he is seen as a young and attractive man, who enchants the women with the sound of his flute and is desired by each one of them. Slowly the character of the play emerges and he is transformed into a more pensive and mature lover. He suffers the pangs of separation, realises his foolishness and focuses all his attention on the only person who, through her intense love and total dedication, can fulfil his desires.

As far as Radha is concerned, she is first introduced in a state of torment, having witnessed her beloved engaged in amorous play with another woman. Withdrawn and wounded, she confides her secret desires and fantasies to her friend. At this moment, the role of the sakhi emerges. In the subsequent songs, the sakhi moves between the two lovers, carrying messages and trying to bring them together.

As Radha journeys through a spectrum of emotions while adorning herself to meet Krishna – anger at his deception, regret for their quarrels and ultimately the realisation of the power of surrender – she is portrayed in successive archetypes of the *nayika*. She appears as the *vasakasajja nayika*, preparing herself for union; as the *khandita nayika*, wounded by betrayal; as the *kalahantarita nayika*, softened by remorse after conflict; as the *abhisarika nayika*, venturing boldly to meet her beloved; and finally as the *swadhinabhartruka nayika*, the woman who, through her unwavering devotion, attains mastery over her lover's heart.

The beauty of spring lends colour and intensity to the unfolding love story. Nature itself becomes a vital presence, playing as significant a role as Radha, Krishna and the sakhis.

As a dancer, choreographer, researcher and eternal admirer of Indian art and culture, I have cherished the joy of invoking the spirit of these compositions in my performances. Watching guruji explore their emotional nuances was a revelation – transforming them into what felt like everyday conversations between two souls embracing the rigours of life.

The *Gita Govinda* opens with two invocations to Vishnu, referring to mythical events occurring beyond the ordinary bounds of time. By doing so, Jayadeva places the eternal love story of Radha and Krishna within a continuous, timeless present frame, unrelated to notions of past and future. In a contemporary context, it gestures towards a world freed from hatred and suffused with love.

Ileana Citaristi

Love – tender, yearning, playful, devotional – has always been at the heart of Indian art and ancient literature. Across poetry, painting, sculpture and classical dance, love is celebrated not just as an emotion but as a powerful metaphor for human longing, spiritual seeking and the relationship between the mortal and the divine. It is this seamless blending of the earthly and the transcendental that gives Indian aesthetics its distinctive depth and beauty.

It is within this vast and layered tradition that Jayadeva's *Gita Govinda* stands as a luminous milestone. My book *Odissi and the Geeta Govinda* is, in essence, a work of love – an offering to Odisha's rich cultural heritage. When I first came to the State 45 years ago, I knew almost nothing about it. I had only heard of its classical dance form. Jayadeva's *Gita Govinda* was one of the things that fascinated me from the very beginning. At first as a compelling romantic tale, and then as an allegorical, philosophical, sensual and spiritual work; all rolled into one.



Soulful strings

Ustad Shahid Parvez and son Shakir to perform in Chennai on Sunday

The Music Academy and HCL Concerts will jointly present a sitar duet by Ustad Shahid Parvez Khan and son Shakir Khan. The duo will be accompanied by Ishaan Ghosh on the tabla. The non-ticketed event will take place on February 15, 6.30 p.m. at T.T. Krishnamachari Auditorium. Belonging to the Etawah

gharana, also known as the Imdadkhani gharana, founded by Ustad Imdad Khan, Shahid Parvez Khan began performing at the age of eight under the guidance of his father, Ustad Aziz Khan. His distinct style allows the sitar to emulate the nuances, meends and emotions of gayaki ang, shifting the focus away from the traditional dhrupad style.

Apart from being a torchbearer of the gharana, Ustad Shahid Parvez brings in his own artistry and approach. Over the years, he has established himself as one of the finest exponents of the instrument. Shakir Khan represents the eighth generation of this musical lineage. Debuting at age 11, Shakir lends a new-age flavour to the tradition. He has not only gained expertise in performing the time-tested compositions of the gharana but also performs fusion concerts across the globe. Together, the father and son will take the audience on a unique musical journey.



An epic retelling

Neha Sathanapalli chronicled the Ramayana through a sequence of events in 'Bhavayami Raghuramam'

Srividya

Neha Sathanapalli, a disciple of Ananda Shankar Jayant, performed at TAG Dakshinamurthy Auditorium, Mylapore as part of Brahma Gana Sabha's annual dance festival.

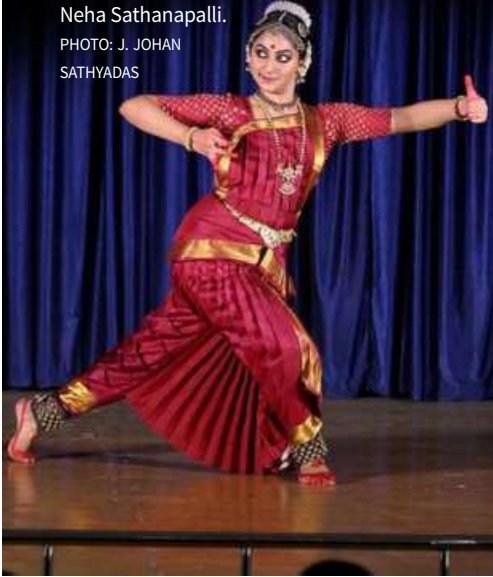
She commenced with a Mallari in Gambhira Nattai, Rupaka tala, which evoked the festive mood that prevailed in Ayodhya when Rama was born — a fitting prelude to the evening's repertoire. 'Bhavayami Raghuramam', a composition by Swati Tirunal in Ragamalika, Rupaka tala, was the main piece of the evening. Choreographed by Ananda Shankar Jayant, it chronicles the story of Rama through a sequence of events, including the Thatakai vadam, Sita Swayamvaram, Guhan helping Rama cross the Ganges, Bharatha meeting Rama and taking his padukas, Shoorpanaka's disfigurement, Sita haranam, choodamani pradhanam, Rama-Ravana yuddham and Rama Pattabhishekam in Ayodhya.

Throughout the recital, Neha's nritta was marked by quick, sharp movements that brought alive the spirit of each of the characters. The dancer's red costume added to the vibrancy of the performance. However, beyond the technical precision, it is the emotional connect that enhances the rasanubhava — an aspect the dancer could develop further.

The recorded musical ensemble included Swetha Prasad on the vocals, Ananda Shankar Jayant and I.V. Renuka Prasad on the nattuvangam, Kolanka Sai Kumar on the violin and T.P. Balasubramanian on the mridangam.

Graceful

Neha Sathanapalli.
PHOTO: J. JOHAN SATHYADAS



Reviving

fading notes

Ravi Rajagopalan and Gayathri Girish's lecture-concert highlighted forgotten strands of the Carnatic repertoire

P Srihari

Imagine a museum of sound where some Carnatic melodies in ragas once popular lie tucked away, seldom heard. Music researcher Ravi Rajagopalan and vocalist Gayathri Girish turned the spotlight on such songs in a lecture-concert on 'Rare ragas and forgotten popular compositions'. Ravi outlined their historical context through his insightful narration while Gayathri revealed their musical character through her thoughtful rendition. They were accompanied by B. Ananthakrishnan on the violin and Melakaveri Balaji on the mridangam.

Organised recently by Madhuradhwani at Arkay Convention Center, the well-curated programme opened with Gayathri singing an invocatory shloka, written by Vidya Jayaraman as a tribute to Muthuswami Dikshitar in ragamalika (Bowli, Kalyani and Ritigowla). This was followed by Veena Kuppaiyer's Ata tala varnam 'Maguva ninne' in Narayanagowla (Mela 22: S R M P N D N S / S N D P M G R G R S). "The raga once held pride of place and was classified under 'Dwiteeya Ghana Raga Panchakam'," shared Ravi. None of Tyagaraja's kritis in it are in vogue today. However, Dikshitar's 'Sriramam ravikulabधि somam' can be heard occasionally, hinting at the raga's existence. 'Ma-ga-ri-ga-ri-sa' is a distinctive usage of the raga which has shades of Kedaragowla and Surutti, and Gayathri's rendition underlined these aspects.

The next raga was Hindolavasantham (Mela 20: S G M P D N D S / S N D M G S).



Informative Ravi Rajagopalan. (Above) Gayathri Girish with B. Ananthakrishnan (violin) and Melakaveri Balaji (mridangam). PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Following a short raga sketch, Gayathri neatly rendered Tyagaraja's 'Ra ra sitaramani manohara' set to Rupakam. Ravi pointed out the absence of the alpa rishabha in this composition as opposed to older lakshanas and Dikshitar kritis such as 'Santhana ramaswaminam', noting that some traditions also employ D2.

A gripping Nattakurinji alapana, suffused with the raga's essence, preceded Pallavi Gopala Iyer's 'Needu murtini' on Vishnu, in Adi tala. Gayathri's niraval and swarakalpana at 'Mandhara giridhara' in the charanam sparked. "This is one of the earliest recorded compositions with a chittaswaram appended to it," said Ravi.

'E mayaladira', a swarajathi in Husseni by Melattur Virabhadrayya (Syama Sastri's guru), was once very popular. Ravi noted that the existence of three distinct versions of the piece points to its popularity earlier. Gayathri presented the version attributed to the Thanjavur Quartet. The most captivating was the opening segment of the charanam 'Ou re ra baagaaya', a lilting phrase

that led to several lyrical variants crafted for different kings and patrons. Over time, somehow, the swarajathi disappeared from the concert stage.

The duo then took up Saamantham (Mela 30), which dates back to the 12th century. It faded into obscurity by the 18th century until Muthuswami Dikshitar revived it, as documented in *Sangita Sampradaya Pradarsini* (SSP). Though the treatise provides no kritis, a couple of them came into being later through Ambi Dikshitar. Saamantham is similar to Sankarabharanam, except that it uses D3 instead of D2. Kritis by Annamacharya in this raga are found in the copper plates of the Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanam, informed Ravi. Gayathri's impressive rendition of Dikshitar's 'Viswanathena rakshitoham' followed a brief alapana. Ananthakrishnan's solo too stood out.

'Mahaganapathim vande' in Thodi-Rupakam by Muthuswami Dikshitar was the next kriti. Though not found in SSP, it first surfaced in 1936 through Natarajasundaram Pillai of the Dikshitar lineage, and is considered highly authentic. Bearing all the hallmarks of a Dikshitar kriti, it features the alpa prayoga of the panchamam. The raga essay, kriti, niraval and swara exchanges at 'Kapilam krishna pujitam' in the charanam were handled with poise, and Balaji's tani was lively.

The engaging presentation concluded with Maha Vaidyanatha Iyer's Kanada thillana 'Gowrinayaka', set to the complex Simhanandana tala (128 aksharas per avartanam), with the full composition covered in just two cycles.

A theatrical ode to the Trinity

Sangeetha Mumoorthigal, a play by United Visuals, offers a glimpse into the lives of Syama Sastri, Tyagaraja and Muthuswami Dikshitar

V.V. Ramani

Encapsulating the greatness of Syama Sastri, Tyagaraja and Muthuswami Dikshitar — the Trinity of Carnatic music — within a single performance is nothing short of a challenge. Yet, United Visuals undertook this formidable task with their latest production, *Sangeetha Mumoorthigal*, staged recently at Hamsadhwani. Conceptualised by writer Veesvee, dramatised by TV. Varadharajan and scripted by Chandramohan with music direction by Bombay Jayashri Ramnath, the play wove together episodes from the lives of these stalwart musicians and composers.

Hailing from the Thanjavur region, it is interesting that the Trinity lived and created music at the same period of time — a phenomenon reminiscent of the Renaissance period in Western art, dominated by Leonardo da Vinci, Michelangelo and Raphael. The play chose to focus on the personal camaraderie among the three and dramatised some significant incidents.

The play opened with an introduction to Syama Sastri set against the backdrop of an agraharam, and then moved on to depict Tyagaraja and Muthuswami Dikshitar. Given the practical constraints that restricted frequent scene changes, the production employed inventive technique of using pertinent imageries. The idols of Devi, Rama and Subramanya were thoughtfully interchanged in the puja-room props to represent the homes and beloved deities of the three legends. The play also drew attention to members of their family, a facet of their lives not widely known.

Incidents of popular appeal such as the rendition of raga Amritavarshini by Dikshitar to

bring rain to a drought-prone land; Tyagaraja's humility and magnanimity in acknowledging the superior quality of music of a nagaswaram vidwan; Syama Sastri rising up to the challenge posed by musician Keshavayya and defeating him; and dance sequences illustrating Dikshitar's contribution towards the music education of the Thanjavur Quartet were incorporated into the play.

Costumes, props and settings were thoughtfully employed to evoke the nativity and cultural milieu of the period.

It is difficult to lip-sync to a recorded voice, but the actors enacted their roles with commendable conviction. Ramesh as Muthuswami Dikshitar appeared a little self-conscious, but Varadharajan as Syama Sastri and Balagurunathan as Tyagaraja were convincing. In a predominantly dialogue-oriented approach, the actors adhered well to the demands of the script.

Some sequences such as Dikshitar learning Hindustani music and his creation of Nottuswarams felt contrived and did not flow well with the narrative. Scene transitions could have been executed in a more professional manner. Selecting appropriate songs from the vast repertoire of compositions by the Trinity can be daunting but Veesvee and Bombay Jayashri chose the ones that perfectly suited the play. And they were incorporated at pertinent moments. Many young musicians have lent their voice to the musical score, conceptualised by Jayashri; but a consistent voice for each of the Trinity would have been more effective.

Despite a seamless flow of scenes, the ending felt abrupt. Perhaps, the play's impact would have been greater had it been anchored by a sutradhar, who would have helped foster a better connect with the audience through his storytelling.



The keeper of a tradition

Tiruttani Swaminathan, an award-winning odhuvar, on embracing change and taking the Tevaram to audiences worldwide

Suganthy Krishnamachari

Fourteen-year-old Sarangapani dropped out of school after class eight due to financial constraints at home. It did not bother him as he was inclined towards music. One day, vocalist Madurai Somu's father-in-law heard him sing, and was impressed. At his suggestion Sarangapani enrolled at the Pichai Kattalai Estate Thevara School in Thirukkadaiyur, where he studied for five years. After this, he continued his music training at Dharmapuram Adheenam School for two years. It was during this period that the pontiff of the Adheenam gave him a new name. Thus, Sarangapani — until then a staunch Vaishnavite — came to be known as Swaminathan.

Once Swaminathan completed his training, he began singing the Tevaram in temples administered by the Adheenam. Then followed a four-year stint at the Kunnakkudi

Adheenam. In 1975, Swaminathan became a full-time odhuvar at the Tiruttani temple, where he served until his retirement in 2000. Post this, he taught at the Chidambaram Thevara Patasalai, and his students have been placed as odhuvurs in temples across the world. Swaminathan, who has been chosen for the Padma Shri (2026), now teaches 49 students at Dharmapuram adheenam school. He continues to sing in Tiruttani during the Padi utsavam and presents Tevaram during kumbabishekams in temples.

"Vaarappaadalgal of Sangam music and devapani of Panchamarabu laid down rules for music, which have been followed in the Tevaram verses. Swaminathan, who has been attending discussions of the Pann Araichi Kazhagam for 40 years, has provided valuable inputs in the analysis of the raga equivalents of *panns*," says Bhageerathy, a member of the Pann Araichi Kazhagam of Tamil Isai



Sangam.

What does the term odhuvar mean? "Odhudal means to recite. From there comes the name odhuvar," explains Swaminathan,

who also clarifies that odhuvar service is not hereditary. Asked if women are prohibited from being odhuvurs, Swaminathan responds: "There are no such restrictions,

although traditionally, only men have been odhuvurs. But now 16 women, who trained in the Karur school, serve in various temples. Interestingly, the old tunes were passed on to posterity, thanks to a woman. When Raja Raja Chola recovered the Tevaram, he was disappointed that the original tunes were lost. He later went to Erukkattampuliyur (Rajendrapattinam), where Thiruneelakanta yazhpana nayanar had lived. Thiruneelakanta Yazhpanar had played the yazh as Gnanasambandar sang his verses. In the presence of the king a woman, who was Thiruneelakanta Yazhpanar's descendant, sang the original tunes, composed by Gnanasambandar, and these were noted down by Nambi Andar Nambi. These events are recorded in Umapathy Sivachariar's *Thirumurai Kanda Puranam*.

About inscriptional evidence for the odhuvar tradition, Swaminathan says, "An inscription

in the Big Temple has a reference about how Raja Raja Chola appointed 48 Tevaram singers, an udukai player and a kotti maddalam player."

What instruments are used now? "We use only the talam (cymbals)," says Swaminathan. How many panns have been used in the Tevaram? "Twenty four. Thirukkurunthogai does not have a *pann* structure, so we can sing these verses in any of the 24 Tevaram panns. There is a lot of interest in Tevaram panns among the diaspora." He has recorded more than 50 discs of Tevaram verses, which are used by Tamilians abroad for learning pann isai.

"Over the years there have been changes in Tevaram. In concerts outside the temple, we have incorporated a few changes. For example, we sing some padhigams a little faster. But nothing has changed in the way we present Tevaram hymns in temples. The aim is to preserve the tradition," says Swaminathan.

ADVERTISEMENT



‘ராமருக்கு உதவிய அணில் போல’.. ஊர் கூடி தேர் இழப்பது போல’..

மதுரை அழகர்கோவில் அருகே

பொய்கைக்கரைப்பட்டியில் கட்டப்பட்டு வரும்

ஸ்ரீ மஹாபெரியவர் ஆலயம்

திருப்பணிக்கு உதவ அன்பு வேண்டுகோள்!



‘இறைவன் குடி கொண்டிருக்கும் ஆலய திருப்பணி செய்வது உன்னதமான பணி!’ என்பதை உணர்த்த, பூசலார் நாயனார் கட்டிய மனக் கோயிலில் எழுந்து அருள் செய்தார் சிவபெருமான்.

‘கருணைக்கடல் காஞ்சி மஹா பெரியவா ஸ்ரீசந்திர சேகரேந்திர சரஸ்வதி ஸ்வாமிகள்’ அருளால், அந்த பாக்கியம் உங்களைத் தேடி வந்திருக்கிறது. 108 திவ்ய தேசங்களில் ஒன்றான, மதுரை கள்ளழகர் கோயில் மலை அடிவாரத்தில், பொய்கைக்கரைப் பட்டியில், இயற்கை எழில் சூழ காஞ்சி மஹா பெரியவர் திருக்கோயிலைக் கட்டி வருகிறது ‘மதுரை அனுஷத்தின் அனுக்கிரஹம் டிரஸ்ட்’.

மதுரையில், ‘ஸ்ரீகாஞ்சி மஹா பெரியவா கிருஹம்’ என்னும் கோயிலை நிர்வகித்து நடத்திவரும் ‘அனுஷத்தின் அனுக்கிரஹம்’ நிறுவனர் நெல்லை பாலு அவர்களின் சீரிய முயற்சியில் அமையவிருக்கிறது இந்தக் கோயில். அரசின் தடையில்லா சான்று உட்பட முறையான அனுமதிகள் அனைத்தும் பெறப்பட்டு போர்வெல், மின் இணைப்புகள் வாங்கி, கோயிலின் அடித்தளப் பணிகள் பூர்த்தி ஆகி விட்டன. தற்போது நிலத்தின் மேல் தளப் பணிகள் தொடங்கியுள்ளன.

அடுத்த ஆண்டுக்குள் கோயில் கட்டுமானம் பூர்த்தி பெற்று, கும்பாபிஷேகம் செய்யப்பட இருக்கிறது. மஹா பெரியவரின் ஆசி பெற்ற பக்தர்களின் பங்களிப்பு இல்லாமல், சர்வ நிச்சயமாக கோயில் கட்டுவது சாத்தியமில்லை! எனவே, அவரது அருளாசிகளைப் பெற்ற பக்தர்கள், ‘ராமருக்கு உதவிய அணில் போல’, தங்களால் முடிந்த வழிகளில் திருப்பணியில் பங்கு பெறும் அரிய வாய்ப்பினைப் பயன்படுத்திக் கொள்ள அன்போடு அழைக்கிறோம்.!

- ★ திருப்பணிக்குப் பணமாக மட்டுமின்றி கட்டிட சாமான்கள், இதர பொருட்களாகவும் வாங்கிக் கொடுக்கலாம்.
- ★ கோயில் அமையவிருக்கிற இடம், கட்டுமானம் சேர்த்து சதுர அடி ஒன்றுக்கு ரூ.3,500 ஆக மெனக் கணக்கிடப்பட்டுள்ளது. சதுரடி வீதமாக ரூ.3,500 அல்லது 2 சதுர அடி, 5 சதுர அடி, 10 சதுர அடி என விரும்பும் அளவுகளில் அதற்கான தொகையை தரலாம்.

- ★ கோயில் அமைவதற்கான செலவுகள் பல லட்சங்களைத் தொடுவதால், ரூ.1 லட்சம் மற்றும் அதற்கு மேல் நன்கொடை தரும் கொடையாளர்களின் பெயர்கள் கல்வெட்டில் பொறிக்கப்பட இருக்கிறது.
 - ★ தாங்கள் அளிக்கும் நன்கொடைகளுக்கு 80G வரி விலக்கும் உண்டு.
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94426 30815

Cheque, M.O. மூலமாகவும் பணம் அனுப்பலாம்



Rtn. நெல்லை பாலு, நிறுவனர், அனுஷத்தின் அனுக்கிரஹம் டிரஸ்ட், G-102, சாந்தி சதன் குடியிருப்பு, கோச்சடை, மதுரை - 625016.



இயலாதோர், ஆதரவற்றோருக்கு உணவு வழங்கி..

முன்னோர் ஆசீர்வாதம் பெறுங்கள்

மதுரையின் அடசயப் பாத்திரம் டிரஸ்ட்

Regd.No.4-50/2021 நன்கொடைகளுக்கு 80G வரிலைக்கு உண்டு



மதுரையில் ரோட்டோரத்தில், மனநலம் பாதிக்கப்பட்டவர்கள் மற்றும் உணவுக்காக தவித்துக் கொண்டிருப்போருக்கு உதவும் விதத்தில் “மதுரையின் அடசயப் பாத்திரம் டிரஸ்ட்” என்ற அமைப்பை தொடங்கி கடந்த 1900 நாட்களுக்கு மேலாக தினமும் 300 பேருக்கு உணவு வழங்கி வருகிறோம்.

தங்களது திருமண நாள், பிறந்த நாள், குழந்தைகளின் பிறந்த நாள், மூதாதையர்களின் நினைவு நாள் மட்டுமின்றி பிற நாட்களிலும் இந்த புனிதப் பணியில் தாங்களும் கரம் கோர்த்தால் இத்திட்டம் வெற்றியடையும் என்பது உண்மை! சந்தோஷத்தில் பெரிய சந்தோஷம் அடுத்தவரை சந்தோஷப்படுத்திப் பார்ப்பதுதான்.



இயலாதவர்கள் மற்றும் மனநலம் பாதிக்கப்பட்டு ரோட்டோரத்தில் இருப்பவர்களின் வயிற்றுப்பசி ஆற்றுவது மூதாதையர்களுக்கு தீதி கொடுப்பதற்கு சமமானது

தானத்தில் சிறந்த தானம் அன்னதானம்

ஒரு நாளுக்கு ஒரு நபருக்கு ரூ.40 வீதம் 300 பேருக்கு ரூ. 12,000 ஆகிறது

50 நபர்களுக்கு - ரூ.2,000 | 200 நபர்களுக்கு - ரூ.8,000

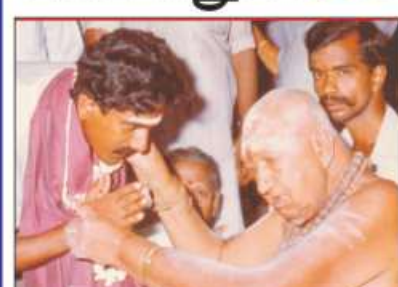
100 நபர்களுக்கு - ரூ.4,000 | 300 நபர்களுக்கு - ரூ.12,000

Rtn. நெல்லை பாலு,
நிறுவனர், மதுரையின் அடசயப் பாத்திரம்,
G-102, சாந்தி சதன் குடியிருப்பு கோச்சடை, மதுரை-16

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தரிசிக்க வாருங்கள்
தினமும் காலை 7.00 - 9.00
மாலை 6.00 - 8.00 மணி
ஒவ்வொரு வியாழக்கிழமையும் மாலை 6 மணிக்கு குருவார சிறப்பு பூஜை நடைபெறும்.
பங்கேற்பவர்களுக்கு ஸ்படிக மாலை பிரசாதமாக வழங்கப்படும்

Rtn. நெல்லை பாலு, நிறுவனர் அனுஷத்தின் அனுக்கிரஹம், செல் : 94426 30815

ஸ்ரீ மஹா பெரியவா கோயில்
13, பொன்மேனி நாராயணன் ரோடு, S.S.காலனி, மதுரை.



Dancer Mythili Prakash and musician Soumik Datta on creating ‘Sahaj’ and viewing the world through art



Neha Kirpal

In the practice of meditation, ‘sahaj’ refers to the idea of blending – where the spiritual and worldly are so integrated that it is like a line drawn on water. “Earlier in my dance journey, it felt like dance was an oasis, free from the fragmentedness, chaos and violence of the world we live in. But increasingly, I see that all of it exists and there is space to experience multiple truths at once, and for me art is the way to express the beauty and power in embracing that,” explained Los Angeles-based contemporary Bharatanatyam dancer Mythili Prakash. It’s probably what prompted Mythili to collaborate with award-winning sarod artiste and composer Soumik Datta to create a two-day festival of music and dance, which began yesterday at Amethyst in Chennai.

‘Sahaj’ is presented by Aalaap and Amethyst, and supported by Soumik Datta Arts, Arts Council England and BNP Paribas. “As a community of artistes too, I see that we are seeking ways to be in dialogue with the rich heritage of our artistic practices and our rapidly globalising world; to use our art forms not just as expressions of celebration and harmony, but also allow them to express the disturbance that we feel about the state of humanity,” she added. As first-generation children of immigrants living in western countries, Mythili and Soumik share a lot of common ground in terms of their artistic journeys – being deeply immersed in classical art forms, while trying to negotiate their relevance for international audiences. Growing up in artistic families, it was this shared experience that led to friendship, critical conversation and observation



Creative prism Mythili Prakash (above); and Soumik Datta; Sayee Rakshith; Debjit Patitundi and Sumesh Narayanan. PHOTOS COURTESY: CHRISTOPHER DUGGAN AND SHAUNAK GOSAVI

Holding space for chaos and beauty

about each other’s work. The duo first performed together in 2021 at Anoushka Shankar’s festival in Germany. Since then, they have become constant “thought partners.” “As NRIs practicing traditional Indian arts, we share a fascination with how heritage and innovation communicate

across borders,” said Soumik. “Sahaj came about because we both want different possibilities of presentation for the art forms we practice, outside of the conventional proscenium setting,” shared Mythili. The festival began with Mythili’s ‘AR | DHA’ and

Soumik will present ‘Travellers’ today. Both these pieces, which were created in residence at and co-produced by G5A in Mumbai, are attempts to converse through art with the cultures of legacy and present-day society. Choreographed and directed by Mythili, ‘AR | DHA’ is an exploration of the iconic mythical dance competition between Shiva and Kali. A two-part work told from both Shiva and Kali’s perspectives, it looks at the dynamics of love and power in this relationship that is at once human and divine. The piece has taken many shapes, including one presented in Qatar during the World Cup, in which Mythili looked at the competition from the angle of “game.” That piece was called ‘One | All’ and centred around the idea of why we are so driven by competition and the desire to name a winner and loser. When Mythili came back to this piece two years later, she

wanted to see it through the perspective of both characters. “To me, at the heart of this piece lies something that is fundamental to us as beings, but – just like Shiva and Kali – when we get caught up in the race that is life, we forget” she said. ‘Travellers’ moves across places, conflicts and emotional terrains, exploring themes of displacement, immigration and identity. According to Soumik, “It’s a deeply sonic experience where Hindustani and Carnatic roots meet sound design, theatrical scenes and rhythmic speech.” The sarod weaves through recordings of war, migration and historical warnings, while tabla, violin and percussion create a constantly shifting sonic landscape. Soumik will be joined on stage by Sayee Rakshith on the violin, Debjit Patitundi on the tabla and Sumesh Narayanan on the mridangam and percussion. Apart from Chennai,

‘Travellers’ will also be presented at Spoken Fest in Mumbai (February 22). Soumik is also scheduled to perform a sarod recital at the Sacred Festival in Amritsar on February 21. February will also see Soumik present a project very close to his heart, ‘Mone Rekho’, in Ahmedabad. Initiated in collaboration with Alzheimer’s Society, and inspired by conversations with people living with dementia, ‘Mone Rekho’ is an immersive audio-visual exploration of memory and the sacred bond between teacher and student. It centres on Soumik’s relationship with his late guru Pt. Buddhadhev Das Gupta. The show has Soumik transitioning between the roles of student, storyteller and master-musician in a space that shifts from concert hall to classroom, care homes and the streets of Kolkata. “It is also a story about the tricks the human mind plays on us. It’s a demanding piece – I narrate, play the sarod and trigger live visuals simultaneously,” explained Soumik. Soumik is also designing the soundscape for Mythili’s upcoming dance play ‘Durga’s Daughters’, a fictional exploration of two women living in present times, holding within them the secret that they are indeed the estranged daughters of goddess Durga. Currently, he is midway through his seven-month long India tour called ‘Melodies in Slow Motion’, which will see him travel to all the four corners of the country to perform, collaborate with young musicians and record in unusual spaces. Post that, Soumik will collaborate with schools, NGOs, British Council and Earth Day Network. “We’ll be using music to support mental health in the youth and environmental awareness, making the arts more accessible to the next generation,” he said.



Trailblazers Suchismita and Debopriya Chatterjee. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

The sound of change

Meet sisters Suchismita and Debopriya, senior disciples of Pt. Hariprasad Chaurasia, who pursued the flute at a time when women flautists in Hindustani music were a rarity

Meena Banerjee

Every January, Vivekananda Hall at Ramakrishna Mission Institute of Culture (RMIC), Kolkata, comes alive with music as part of Swami Vivekananda’s birth anniversary celebrations. This year too, RMIC organised a day-long event to celebrate Swami Vivekananda’s 163rd birth anniversary – including a duet by violinist Kala Rammath and vainika Jayanti

Kumaresh. Music lovers, who looked forward to veteran flautist Pt. Hariprasad Chaurasia to give his annual ‘haziri’ (he has been a regular at the event) were disappointed. Unfortunately, his physical condition forced him to step back. Instead, the Chatterjee sisters – Suchismita and Debopriya – his senior disciples, performed at the event. The audience was surprised to see the sisters on stage with the flute, an instrument rarely associated with women in Hindustani

classical music, though it has long found resonance with women musicians in the Carnatic tradition. The Chatterjee sisters, accompanied by Ojas Adhiya, looked resplendent as they delivered Shuddh Sarang with impressive command, concluding the morning session on a luminous note. The opening of their concert was less mysterious and more precise and sparkled like their beautiful eyes. Yet, their technique and musical thought carried the imprint

of their master. During a chat after the concert, the duo said they feel blessed to have participated in the event that for the first time had women musicians perform. Debopriya shared that their journey was never defined by their gender. “Our vocalist-parents, Pt. Robin Chatterjee and Krishna, were settled in Allahabad. They encouraged us to learn to play the flute in late 1980s when there were no women flautists in Hindustani music. Pt. Bholanath Prasanna ji and later our guruji (Hariprasad Chaurasia) were more than happy to have us as their disciples and there has never been any discrimination.” Debopriya then reflected on why the flute has been a male-dominated domain. “Even the sitar, sarod and percussion instruments were played by very few women musicians earlier, let alone wind instruments such as the flute or the shehnai. Actually, the flute is not as simple as it looks. It demands immense lung power.”

When reminded about what Pt. Hariprasad Chaurasia’s had said that the flute is a simple instrument and easy to play, the sisters laughed and said, “It is the simplicity of the instrument that makes it difficult too. It has no strings, wires, frets or pegs to tune it. It’s just a hollow piece of bamboo with holes drilled into it. One needs tremendous practice to master it. Guruji also says that to be able to play the flute, you need to be tuneless from within.” Debopriya also spoke about their efforts to bring classical music to newer audiences. “Recently, we performed at a mall. The idea was to take classical music to the public, especially youngsters. Unlike film music, classical music often requires a conscious decision even to listen to it. While it has traditionally appealed to a niche audience, its charm and relevance have remained timeless.”

A deep dive into devotion

A musical dialogue between songs that celebrate the form and the formless of bhakti tradition



Seamless convergence Bhuvanesh Komkali and Jayateerth Mevundi with Mandar Puranik (tabla), Dhyaneswar Sonawane (samvadini), Sunil Kumar (bansuri) Varsha (vocal support), Suryakant Surve (manjira) and Sukhad Munde (pakhawaj).

Vaishali K.S.

Tuka Mhane, Kahe Kabira’ – a unique musical event organised by Pancham Nishad was recently held at Chowdhia Memorial Hall, Bengaluru. Vocalists Bhuvanesh Komkali and Jayateerth Mevundi commenced the concert with Sant Jnaneshwar’s abhang ‘Tuj sagun manu ki nirgun re’. The composition alluded to the two trajectories of bhakti – worship of the ‘saguna’ (characterised by a specific form) versus ‘nirguna’ (formless). These paradoxical dualities were represented by the abhangs of Sant Tukaram and the mystical dohas of Sant Kabir. The stage setting too was in consonance with the theme. Jayateerth’s rendition of the ‘saguni’ ‘Rajasa sukumar, madanancha puttala’ depicting the beautiful, regal form of Vittala in raag Shivranjini had a captivating appeal. This was followed by another abhang of Sant Tukaram bearing affinity to a ‘nirguni’ conception: ‘Anureniya thokada, tuka akasha evada’ where he describes himself as an insignificant person and at the same time as vast and

expansive as the sky, referring to his corporeal self as an illusion. The abhang immortalised by Pt. Bhimsen Joshi in raag Malkauns was rendered with fervour by Jayateerth, highlighting both the ‘sagun’ and ‘nirgun’ conceptions. Bhuvanesh Komkali embarked on a deeply meditative musical journey with the profound nirguni Kabir bhajan, ‘Niharwa humka na bhava’ – a bride’s longing for her natal home as the metaphor for the soul’s yearning for the divine – in taal Deepchandi, re-articulating the astounding blend of classical and folk elements in his grandfather and maestro Pt. Kumar Gandharva’s rendition. This was followed by another nirguni Kabir bhajan ‘Sunta hai guru gyani, gagan mein awaz ho rahi jeeni jeeni’, characterised by a unique melodic structure bearing the stamp of Pt. Kumar Gandharva’s inimitable style and reminiscent of folk melodies of Malwa. Jayateerth’s soulful delineation of another nirguni Kabir bhajan ‘Guru bin kaun batave baat’ in raag Madhuvanti was marked by a contemplative solemnity and gravitas that transformed into a sprightly abhang ‘Ma

ganadeva’, followed by a sonorous chanting of the ‘gajar’ ‘Jnanoba, Mauli Tukaram’. Bhuvanesh Komkali presented another riveting Kabir composition: ‘Kaun thugwa nagariya lital ho’ (which thief has plundered this city?) – a philosophical song about mortality and the inexorability of time rendered in a lilting Manj Khamaj. Jayateerth’s counterpoint to this was a poignant Kannada bhajan ‘Yake mookanadyo guruve’ by Jagannatha Dasaru of the Madhwa sampradaya in raag Jaunpuri. In this devotional musical odyssey, the two vocalists were accompanied by an adept ensemble of accompanists – Mandar Puranik (tabla), Dhyaneswar Sonawane (samvadini), Sunil Kumar (bansuri), Varsha (disciple of Bhuvanesh Komkali on vocal support), Suryakant Surve (manjira) and Sukhad Munde (pakhawaj). Bhuvanesh Komkali and Jayateerth Mevundi concluded the evening with a mesmerising joint rendition of the Kabir composition: ‘Avadhoota gagan ghata geheerayire’ in raag Bhairavi and Keherwa taal.



Star performer Shemekia Copeland returns to Mumbai for her third outing at the annual Mahindra Blues Festival

Narendra Kusnur

Vocalist Shemekia Copeland, daughter of guitarist and singer Johnny Copeland, will make her third appearance at the annual Mahindra Blues Festival (MBF). The festival will be held on February 14 and 15 at Mehboob Studios, Mumbai. She first came for the inaugural edition in 2011, along with the legendary Buddy Guy, the young Jonny Lang and British guitarist Matt Schofield. She was back again in 2017, when the line-up included the veteran Billy Gibbons of the band ZZ Top, who played with

the trio California Blues Machine, and young prodigy Quinn Sullivan. Also returning to the event are Schofield and American guitarist Eric Gales. The line-up includes the Milwaukee, US, group Altered Five Blues Band, Louisiana musician D.K. Harrell, who makes his MBF debut, and Indian act Blackstratblues, the brainchild of guitarist Warren Mendonsa. Bengaluru-based Grace 'n' the Cliches, winners of this year's Mahindra Blues Hunt, will also perform. Shemekia is "excited to be back. The earlier experiences were incredible. India is like no place in the world. This festival is like a vacation, combined with a party."

Recalling her previous experience, she adds: "I went into town every day, had lunch at the Khyber restaurant, tea at the Taj Mahal hotel, and shopped. I also Blues had to evolve to stay contemporary. Today, the lyrics are less about the past and love affairs gone wrong and more about women's problems, gun violence and crooked politicians

SHEMEKIA COPELAND

visited Mumbadevi Temple. This time, I would like to start breakfast every day with a nice, tasty dosa. Later on, some pomfret." According to Shemekia, festivals such as MBF help amplify the blues and introduce audiences to the music, specially in regions outside the US and Europe. Born and raised in Harlem, New York, in 1979, the blues has been a part of Shemekia's life. "My father always played the blues and wrote songs in our house. It was fun when his musician friends come over. My favourite singers were Koko Taylor, Otis Redding and O.V. Wright. Thanks to my father, I was also introduced to rhythm 'n' blues and soul; and we heard a lot of

Sam Cooke while in the car." Among the younger blues artistes, Shemekia mentions 26-year-old blues-rock guitarist and singer-songwriter Ally Venable as her favourite. Though she's grown up on blues and soul, Shemekia also listens to other genres. She then talks of her encounters with the Grateful Dead's Bob Weir, who passed away on January 10 and shares: "Bobby was really sweet, low-key and humble. He was cool. I first met him in an elevator because we were staying in the same hotel. At first, I was shy about meeting him but he made me feel comfortable. Fortunately I was on stage with him later and we were able to laugh about it." Shemekia first stepped on the stage with her father at New York's Cotton Club when she was eight. She released her debut *Turn The Heat Up* in 1998 when she was 18, and instantly became a blues and R&B force to be reckoned with. She has won nine Blues Music Awards and five Blues Blast Music Awards. Her last album *Blame It On Eve* was released in 2024, and received three Grammy nominations for Best American Roots Performance, Best American Roots Song and Best Contemporary Blues Album. She says, "What thrilled me and my team was that we were nominated not only for blues but also in the roots categories." *Blame It On Eve* was recorded in Nashville and produced by instrumentalist-songwriter Will Kimbrough, who also produced her previous three albums. It features 12 new songs that tackle subjects such as a woman's right to choose, climate change and separation. But it also has its fun songs like 'Wine O' Clock', her father's tune 'Down On Bended Knee' and the Stevie Wonder-popularised 'Heaven Help Us'. Shemekia feels blues songs have changed in content since she forayed into the field in the late 1990s and elaborates, "Blues had to evolve to stay contemporary. Today, the lyrics are less about the past and love affairs gone wrong and more about women's problems, gun violence and crooked politicians."

CALENDAR

Shivaratri special

● Naadhabrahmam has organised a night-long music event to celebrate Mahashivaratri from February 15, 6 p.m. to February 16, 6 a.m. at Sudarshan Kalyana Mahal, Naganallur. The line-up will feature the following performances: Feb. 15, 6.30 p.m.: Panniru Tirumurai rendition by G. Subramanian Odhuvar; 8 p.m.: 'Shivan Maghimai', dance drama by Premalaya Natyaniketan; 10 p.m.: namasankirtanam by Srivanchiyam Gurujikrupa Mandali; Feb. 16, 12.01 a.m.: discourse by Abishek Raju, Sowmiya Abishek Raju and Samarth Raju; 2 a.m.: Saisharan (vocal); and 4 a.m.: Sruthi S. Bhat (vocal). Justice C. Saravanan, Judge, The Madras High Court, will inaugurate and confer the title 'Naadha Padhika Sevaka' upon Courtallam G. Subramanian Odhuvar on the occasion. Live on dinamalar.com.

● Madhuradhwani and Carnatica Global have jointly organised the following concerts as part of Shivaratri on February 15. It begins with a special puja at 2.30 p.m. followed by Thirumeignanam Brothers' nagaswaram recital; 4 p.m.: Nirmala Rajasekar (veena); 4.50 p.m.: Nisha Rajagopalan; 5.40 p.m.: Amritha Murali; 6.30 p.m.: R.K. Shriramkumar and Amritha Murali (vocal support); 7.20 p.m.: K. Gayatri; 8.10 p.m.: Palghat R. Rampasad; 9 p.m.: R. Suryaprakash; 9.50 p.m.: Gayathri Girish and Vishshruthi Girish (vocal duet); 10.40 p.m.: J.B. Keerthana; 11.30 p.m.: V. Shankar Narayanan; 12.20 a.m.: Vidya Kalyanaraman; 1.10 a.m.: V.K. Manimaran; 2 a.m.: B.U. Ganesh Prasad; 2.50 a.m.: Vasudha Ravi; 3.40 a.m.: Shruthi Shankar Kumar; 4.30 a.m.: Sri Sri Sisters; 5.20 am Patangi Brothers; 6.10 a.m. Dhanya Dinesh Rudrapatnam; 7.00 a.m. Anirudh Subramaniam and 7.50 am - Archana & Samanvi - Vocal Duet.

Centenary celebrations

Natya Manjari marked the inauguration of Shatavaarshikotsava — the birth centenary guru Udupi Laxminarayan — on January 31. As part of the celebration, Natya Manjari, will host a series of monthly events till June at Narada Gana Sabha mini hall. It will culminate in a grand event on July 26 at Narada Gana Sabha, where distinguished male dancers from Bharatanatyam and cinema will be honoured. The event will end with a special performance by popular choreographers Prabhu Deva and Nagendra Prasad.

Vocal concerts

- Hamsadhwani's 36th annual festival will feature the following performances at Youth Hostel, Adyar: Today, 6.15 p.m.: Aishwarya Shankar (vocal) with Hemalatha (Violin), Manoj Siva (Mridangam).
- Tomorrow, 6.15 p.m.: Amritha Murali (Vocal) with R.K. Shriram Kumar (violin), K. Arun Prakash (mridangam) and N. Guruprasad (ghatam).



Stories in Tamil

Storycorner at Bookmine, as part of the Chennai Storytelling Festival 2026, presents the 10th edition of a special segment in Tamil titled 'Thamizhil Kadhaigal Ketpom' (Let's listen to stories in Tamil) on February 14, 3 p.m. on Zoom. Themed 'Inraya Samudhayam — Oru Kannadi Pidithu Parthal Enna Theriginrathu' (in Tamil) will feature sessions by 10 storytellers including Haritha Kannan, Kousalya Pari, Padma Jairam, Shyama Sridharan and Thenmozhi Sampath. The event is open to adults and children over 10 years. V. Sreevatson (Dummies Drama) will be the chief guest. For more details email to storycornerat bookmine@gmail.

Voice from the Valley

Faheem Abdullah, the singer behind *Saiyaara*'s hit title track, on his journey from Kashmir to Bollywood



Bindu Gopal Rao

Do you know who the voice behind the title track of the 2025 sleeper hit Hindi film *Saiyaara* is? Meet 28-year-old Faheem Abdullah, who shares his journey from the Valley to the studios of Mumbai. For someone who has always been drawn to art in some form, Faheem took to writing while still in school, mostly to process what he was feeling, which resulted in his very first song: 'Teri Yaad'. "It stayed with me for years and was released much later. Music, for me, didn't begin as a career choice, but as an instinct. Writing and composing became a space where I could be honest without explanation, and that honesty slowly became my sound," says Faheem, who got his first real break during an India tour he undertook with a friend. "We were travelling with just our music and a strong

sense of belief. When we reached Mumbai things began to change quietly. I met the team at Artist First and also Tanishk Bagchi," shares Faheem, who adds that none of these meetings were planned or strategically pursued, but "happened organically." Hailing from Kashmir, Faheem says, is something he carries with pride. "It shapes how I feel, write and see the world. There's a certain stillness, longing, and emotional depth that comes from the place, and that finds its way into my music subconsciously." One of his early releases, 'Jhelum', reflects this. He does not try to translate his roots deliberately, but they exist in the pauses, silences and emotions of his music. "I believe emotions are universal. Love, loss, hope and longing don't belong to a particular geography. My aim is to tell stories that feel personal and resonate beyond borders." He started as an independent artiste and says it was a phase that

taught him everything. "The challenges are real. You're doing multiple things at once — learning and navigating uncertainty. But the reward is freedom. Even now as I work on multiple projects, I try to hold on to that independence in thought. Every phase has its pros and cons, and I'm learning to embrace all of them as part of the journey," he says. One emotion he enjoys exploring in his music is love in all its hues. "The beginning, the longing, the distance, the silence, the healing — this kind of music allows people to see themselves in it." So was the genesis and the journey of the 2024 romantic song film song 'Ishq', a turning point that helped him gain momentum and opened up opportunities. Working Mohit Suri (director of *Saiyaara*) was a dream, says Faheem, as his "understanding of music and emotion is incredible. Tanishk (Bagchi) dada was one of the first people I met in Mumbai, and has been an important part of my journey. Both supported me at crucial moments, and those collaborations taught me about discipline, scale and storytelling through music." Faheem draws inspiration from different genres and is a fan of RY X and Parvaaz. "Their music is honest and atmospheric. I think the inspiration comes more from feeling than from format, and I try to stay open to that." About his upcoming debut stage show in Bengaluru, Faheem says: "Performing live is an important part of this journey. Bengaluru has played a huge role in shaping my creative voice." About the Kashmiri music scene, Faheem hopes more voices find platforms and audiences across the country and beyond. "There's so much talent waiting to be heard," he says.

Faheem Abdullah will perform in Bengaluru on February 14 at Bhartiya City.

Chronicles of Palimaru Matha

The book *Divine Legacy of Shri Palimaru Matha*, authored by Sudheendhra Putty, pays a tribute to the illustrious parampara of Shri Palimaru Matha, one of the eight mathas founded by Sri Madhwacharya in the 13th century CE. Sudheendhra Putty's works include translations of seminal Sanskrit texts such as *Sampradaya Paddhati* and

Mangalashtaka, and a recent coffee-table book chronicling the 800-year spiritual and cultural legacy of Palimaru Matha and its seers. The book begins with an exposition of the Dvaita philosophy, enriched by reflections from scholars such as S. Radhakrishnan and Prof. S.N. Dasgupta. Commissioned in English by the present pontiff, Shri Vidyadheesha Teertha Swami, the volume captures the grandeur of the Matha's festivals, its revered deities, preservation of sacred Sarvamoola manuscripts and social initiatives.

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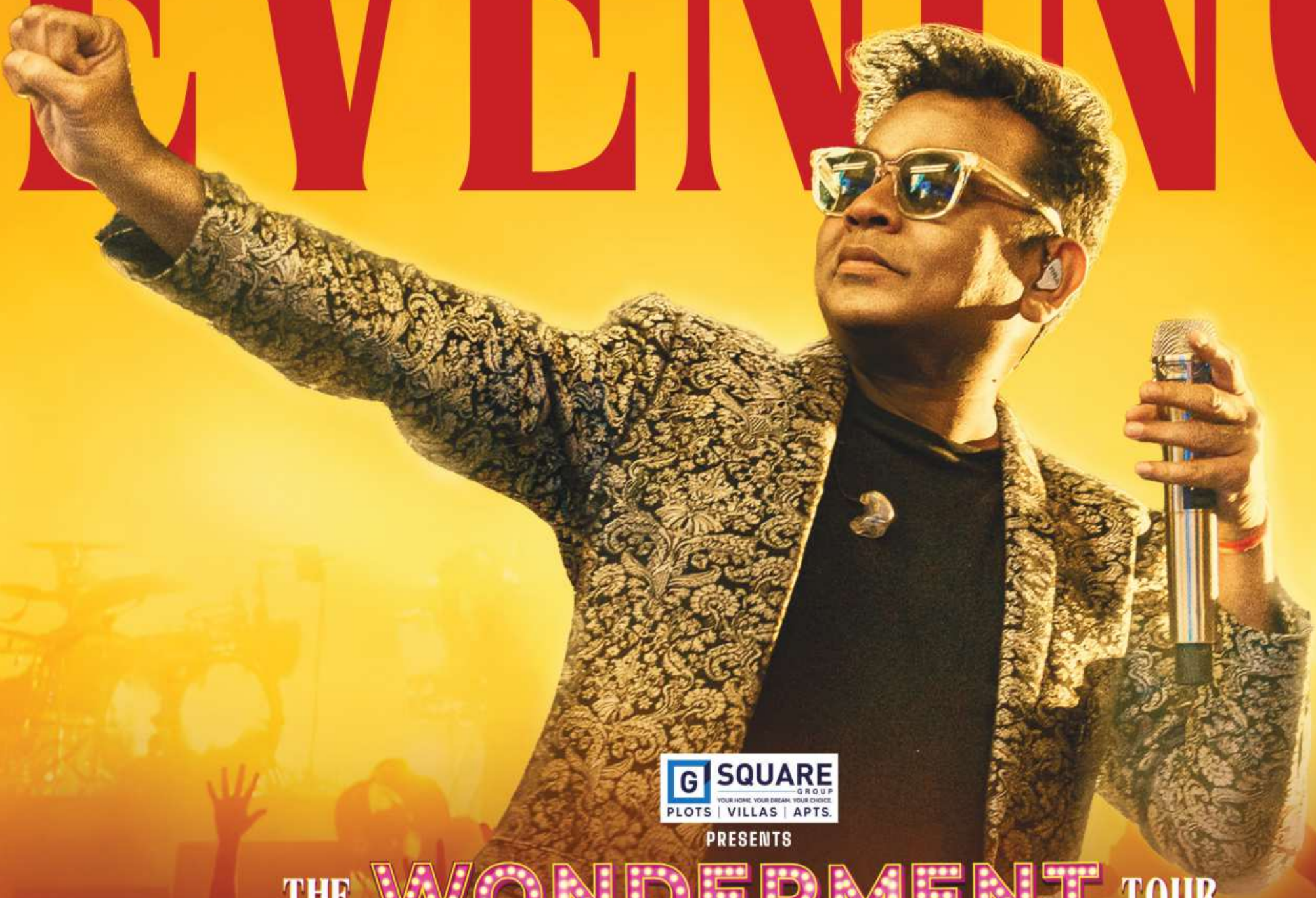
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